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WELFARE ACCOUNTING
Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel

GUJARAT

CM PATEL'S DIGITAL RAP

By Jumana Shah

analysed by a team of professionals. "It completes the cycle, from collecting data to monitoring to ensuring timely disposal of cases, and also ranks officers for their performance. The analysis report prepared by the dashboard team has become an important point of discussion in the committee of secretaries (CoS) meeting every week," the officer adds. In August 2022, CM Patel even monitored the law and order situation in the state during the 145th Jagannath rath yatra using the CM's Dashboard.

Integration and collection of data is one part of the CM Dashboard. This basic framework is further integrated with the respective officers—secretaries, collectors, DDOs, municipal commissioners—for performance monitoring. The real-time monitoring system is unique to the CM Dashboard. "The command and control unit—through which the monitoring happens—gives a macro level picture of the state with performance of each district. It shows which ones are leading and which are laggards," the officer in the CMO explains.

Meanwhile, the WhatsApp bot is used as a tool to make the CM 'accessible' to people on their handheld devices. It gives automated close-ended responses that are delivered to the CM's inbox, which is meticulously monitored by officers on special duty (OSDs) in the CMO. People can 'Write to CM' for direct complaints or suggestions, or even send a season's greetings message. Other functions include making an appointment for Swagat, fixing an appointment with the CM as well as applying for benefits under the CM's relief fund.

In the three months since the launch in January 2023, 43,068 messages had been received till April 30, of which 33.4 per cent were to convey a greeting to the CM or pass on a suggestion. "We construe this as a sign of the people connecting with the CM personally," says the officer in the CMO. The second highest number of requests (17 per cent) have come for an appointment with the CM. "The request goes to the CM's appointment desk, where the SOP (standard operating procedure) for granting appointments is followed," the officer adds.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who kicked off the digitisation initiative in 2003 during his first term as the CM of Gujarat, also addressed officers during the anniversary celebration of Swagat in the last week of April. "Governance is not static, it has to innovate to employ the latest methods and technology for the benefit of the people. It has to have empathy. A government's complaint redressal system is the most important benchmark of democracy," he reiterated. The legacy endures. ■